a field guide to partners and patterns



Who Brings Out *Your Best*

How each archetype loves in a couple, the partner who lights up her gifts, the one who feeds her shadow, and the fights she keeps having.

7 portraits
OF YOU IN A COUPLE

14 recurring fights
AND HOW TO BREAK THEM

7 pages for him
TO READ, OR TO HAND OVER

before you begin

Chemistry is a question, not an answer

You have probably met a man who looked perfect on paper and felt wrong in your body, and another who looked like a mismatch and turned out to be the kindest person you've ever loved. Compatibility isn't a pair of types that click. It's whether his way of loving feeds your gifts or your shadow.

So you won't find a box to put him in here. The focus is on what he does, because you don't live with a type, you live with behavior: how he acts when you're sad, whether he can take no for an answer, if he's affectionate on a boring Thursday, how he treats you when his own week was rough. In your thirties and forties those questions matter more than ever. You may be choosing someone to build a home or a family with, blending lives that already have kids, careers and exes in them, or deciding whether a long relationship still fits.

In each chapter: your archetype at her best with a partner, her gifts and needs, the kinds of partners who light her up or wear her down, two arguments she tends to repeat with a way out of each, and a page meant for him. Begin with the archetype that leads in you, then visit the ones that show up second and third. One partner can draw out the best of your Strategist and the worst of your Nurturer in a single week.

> USE IT AS A COMPASS, NOT A VERDICT
>
> A partner who brings out your best doesn't guarantee a happy ending, and one who triggers your shadow isn't automatically the wrong man. Nearly everyone does some of each. What helps is seeing the pattern clearly enough to name it together.

If you're single

This isn't a catalog for picking a man. Use your chapter to understand yourself, then study the next page: those five behaviors reveal more about a person than any label.

Inside every chapter

1
You at your best
A scene from a good day in a couple.

2
Bring and need
Your gifts, and what keeps them alive.

3
Best and shadow
The partners who light you up or wear you down.

4
The repeat fights
Two loops, what drives them, what to try.

5
For him
A page to read together, plus a ritual.

for every archetype

Five things that matter more than any type

None of these are personality traits. They're things a person does, so you can spot them early and keep checking for them for years. Where they're present, almost every archetype in you relaxes into her gift. Where they're missing, the shadows take over, no matter which ones you carry.

1

He repairs.

Every couple fights. What matters is what happens after. Does he come back with an apology, a touch, a joke, a “can we try that again”? Long-running research on couples finds that repair after conflict predicts staying together far better than how rarely you argue.

2

He's still curious about you.

He asks questions and remembers the answers. Months or years in, he still wants to know what you think about things, not just what's for dinner. Curiosity is the opposite of taking someone for granted.

3

He carries his share of the invisible work.

Remembering birthdays, booking the dentist, noticing the milk is out. In your thirties this load gets heavy fast. A man who handles his part without being managed protects every archetype in you from burnout.

4

He can hear “no” and “I'm upset” without punishing you.

No sulking, no cold shoulder, no turning your feelings into his crisis. If you can disagree with him safely, you'll stop rehearsing every hard conversation in your head.

5

His life is going somewhere of its own.

He has friends, interests and a direction, and he takes care of his own moods. He isn't looking for a mother, a rescuer or an audience. He's looking for a partner, and so are you.

at a glance

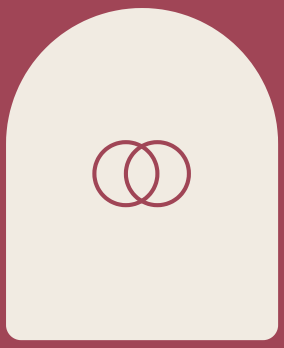
The map

Seven rows, seven ways of loving: her gifts, her needs, and the partner behaviors that lift her up or drag her down. Start with the row that feels most like you, then glance at the rest.

	HER GIFTS	HER NEEDS	LIGHTS HER UP	WEARS HER DOWN	
The Romantic	Aliveness, touch, desire that lasts	Steady warmth, nothing to chase	A man who is quietly, reliably warm	Hot-and-cold attention	*p. 5*
The Oracle	Depth, early warning, meaning	Silence, solitude, trust in her hunches	A grounded listener who helps her check the facts	A man who dismisses what she senses	*p. 7*
The Strategist	Clear sight, fairness, honesty	Directness and real conversation	An open book who argues with affection	Mixed signals; scorn for feelings	*p. 9*
The Trailblazer	Freedom, loyalty, momentum	Space, and closeness by choice	A teammate with a full life of his own	A man who clings or competes	*p. 11*
The Sovereign	Vision, stability, standards	Follow-through, shared decisions	An equal who keeps his word	A passenger, or a rival	*p. 13*
The Nurturer	Tenderness, depth, devotion	To be asked, helped and rested	A man who notices and steps in	A man who needs saving	*p. 15*
The Dreamer	Lightness, curiosity, hope	Patience and clarity	A patient, clear partner	Ambiguity, or a man who directs	*p. 17*

A NOTE ON HIM

You may recognize your partner in these rows too. That's useful: half of every recurring fight is two people protecting two different needs. If you can name his, you can stop taking it personally.



IN A COUPLE · 01 OF 07

The Romantic

Love, felt all the way through.

In a couple, you are the warmth. You keep the body, the pleasure and the sense of occasion alive long after the first year. Your growing edge is telling closeness apart from chasing.

A rainy Saturday with nowhere to be. You've made the good coffee, there's a record on, and his head is in your lap while you read. You notice the weight of him, the rain, the smell of the pages, and you are completely content. That's you in a couple, at full strength: not performing romance, simply enjoying the person next to you, and letting him feel enjoyed.

What you bring

ALIVENESS

With you, takeout becomes a picnic on the floor and a Tuesday can feel like an occasion. He remembers that life is meant to be tasted.

GENEROUS RECEIVING

You take in his compliments and his care instead of waving them away, so giving to you feels wonderful.

DESIRE THAT LASTS

You don't let a long relationship turn into roommates. You flirt, you initiate, and you keep touch and desire part of the story.

What keeps you well loved

- Warmth that stays steady when nothing special is happening.
- Touch with no agenda: a hand on your neck, his foot against yours.
- Reassurance offered before you have to fish for it.
- Unhurried time together that isn't about chores or plans.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The steady flame

Consistently, unspectacularly warm. He texts in the afternoon for no reason and is glad to see you on a Monday. Your nervous system finally exhales.

The fellow savorer

He enjoys a meal, a song, a slow morning as much as you do, so pleasure is shared instead of carried by you alone.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The intermittent man

Wonderful one week, gone the next. The highs feel like proof, the lows feel like your fault, and you start to chase.

The man who uses closeness as an eraser

He reaches for you instead of talking. It feels like making up, and the real issue waits for the next fight.

IN THE LONG RUN

Kids, a mortgage and tired evenings can make desire feel like a memory. Your gift is reminding both of you that it isn't. Your risk is reading a quiet season as rejection. Put pleasure on the calendar without apologizing for it, and say what you miss without blame: “I miss being flirted with. Can we bring that back?”

The fights you keep having

The unanswered afternoon

You send something sweet at noon. He answers at seven with "lol yes." By then you've drafted two follow-ups and decided something is wrong. He walks in cheerful; you're cool. He has no idea what happened.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Silence registers in your body as a threat to the bond, so a busy day reads like love being withdrawn.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Before you react, give yourself something pleasant: a walk, a song, a bath. Then say it plainly: "I missed you today." No test, no edge.

Making up without talking

You argue about money or his mother, it gets heated, then suddenly close, and you end up laughing in bed. A month later, the same argument, almost word for word.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Closeness is your safest place, so you use it to make the bad feeling stop, and the hurt never gets said.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Closeness is fine; just put the words first: one honest line first ("It stung that you decided without me"), let him answer, then come close.

Words to borrow

"Forget grand gestures. I'd love it if you made the first move sometimes."

"If you're going to be offline, just tell me. It saves me a whole afternoon."

"Can we talk first, and then come here?"

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE A ROMANTIC

- Reach for her often and for no reason. Small and frequent beats big and rare.
- If you'll be hard to reach, say so in advance.
- Let her enjoy you, and let her see you enjoy her.
- Don't use intimacy to skip a hard talk. Talk first, then come close.
- Tell her what you love about your ordinary life together.

A RITUAL FOR TWO

Phones-in-a-drawer night

One evening a week, both phones go in a drawer and pleasure is the only plan: cook something good, dance in the kitchen, run a bath, talk on the floor. No problem-solving allowed.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

Steady is not boring. Steady is where I get to rest.



IN A COUPLE · 02 OF 07

The Oracle

Love that reads between the lines.

In a couple, you are the depth. You sense what's unspoken, notice what matters, and give the relationship meaning. Your growing edge is saying out loud what you already know.

Late evening on the balcony. Neither of you has spoken in ten minutes, and it's the most connected you've felt all week. Then you say quietly, “You're worried about your dad, aren't you?” and he exhales, because he was. That's you in a couple, at full strength: present, perceptive, making room for what hasn't been said yet.

What you bring

DEPTH

Conversations with you go somewhere real. He finds himself saying things he has never said out loud.

EARLY WARNING

You sense trouble, in him, in the two of you, in a friend, long before it surfaces, which gives you both time.

MEANING

You remember the anniversaries, build small rituals, and remind him your life is more than a to-do list.

What keeps you well loved

- A partner who is comfortable with silence.
- Someone who takes your hunches seriously, then helps you check them.
- Time alone to recharge, without it being read as rejection.
- Everyday dependability that roots you in real life.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The grounded listener

He never mocks a hunch. He asks, “What are you picking up on?” and helps you match the feeling with facts.

The reliable man

Predictable in the best sense: he calls when he says he will. His steadiness lets you come out of your head.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The dismisser

“You're overthinking it.” “That's crazy.” Every time he waves away what you sense, you go further inward.

The beautiful enigma

Moody, poetic, often unavailable. You spend months decoding him and call it a deep connection.

IN THE LONG RUN

Over the years you can become the one who reads everything and says little. He stops asking, you stop offering, and the silence that once felt intimate starts to feel like distance. Keep one deep conversation a week alive, and tell him what you sense about the two of you, even when it's uncomfortable.

The fights you keep having

The silent evening

Something he said at dinner stung. You don't mention it; you just go quiet. He asks if you're okay and you say yes. He spends the night feeling shut out; you spend it feeling unseen.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

You go inward to process, and part of you hopes he'll sense what you sense without being told.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Leave a light on: "Something hurt at dinner. I need an hour, then I want to talk." Then come back and say it in plain words.

The feeling versus the facts

You have a strong feeling about a decision: the apartment, his job offer, a new friend. He wants pros and cons. You feel dismissed; he feels like he's arguing with a mood.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Your knowing arrives before your reasons, so it's hard to defend in his language.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Translate. Say what you sense, then add one thing you've actually seen: "I have a bad feeling about the landlord. He dodged two questions about the heating."

Words to borrow

"I'm going quiet to think, not to leave you."

"I have a feeling about this. Can we look at it together?"

"Ask me what I'm noticing. I'll tell you."

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE AN ORACLE

- When she goes quiet, ask gently once, then let her be.
- Take her intuition seriously, then help her test it.
- Be reliable in small things. It's how she learns to trust the ground.
- Protect her alone time, and expect her to come back.
- Ask big questions sometimes. She lights up when you go deep.

A RITUAL FOR TWO

The question jar

Fill a jar together with big questions. Once a week, each of you pulls one and answers out loud: "What did you need as a kid that you didn't get?" "What are you quietly proud of?" Listen without fixing.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

What I sense matters, and so does saying it.



IN A COUPLE · 03 OF 07

The Strategist

Love with her eyes open.

In a couple, you are the clarity. You see the real issue, play fair, and never make him guess. Your growing edge is letting feelings in before the analysis.

Sunday, two coffees, the news split between you, and an argument about a headline that's half serious and half flirting. He makes a good point and you concede, delighted. That's you in a couple, at full strength: engaged, honest, and enjoying a mind that keeps up with yours.

What you bring

CLEAR SIGHT

You see the pattern behind a fight, the real issue under the dishes, and can name it without blame.

FAIRNESS

You can hold both sides of a disagreement, which makes conflict with you surprisingly safe.

HONEST TALK

No games, no hints. He never has to guess what you think, and for most men that is a relief.

What keeps you well loved

- Real conversation, every day.
- Directness and consistency, so there's nothing to decode.
- Patience while you warm up to closeness.
- Gentle invitations into feeling, not demands.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The open book

He says what he feels and means what he says. With nothing to decode, your mind rests and your heart has room.

The warm debater

He loves your mind, argues back with affection, and pulls you into a hug mid-sentence.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The mixed signal

Warm, then vague. Keen, then quiet. Your mind goes into overdrive, and the relationship becomes a puzzle instead of a home.

The feelings skeptic

He jokes that emotions are drama. With him you stay in your head, where it's safe, and lonely.

IN THE LONG RUN

In a long relationship you can slide into running it like a well-managed project: efficient, fair, a little cool. Logistics replace curiosity. Ask him one question a week you don't know the answer to, and let yourself be surprised by the man you think you already understand.

The fights you keep having

The cross-examination

He forgot dinner with your friends. You lay out exactly how this fits a pattern, with three examples. You're right. He shuts down. You end the night correct and alone.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Logic feels safer than hurt, so you lead with the case instead of the feeling.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Start with one feeling sentence: “I felt unimportant tonight.” Then stop. Let the evidence wait.

The analysis loop

He said “we'll see” about the summer trip. You spend two days dissecting it, ask a friend, reread the thread. When you finally ask, he just hadn't checked his calendar.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Uncertainty feels dangerous, and thinking feels like control.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Use a one-day rule: if something has been on your mind for twenty-four hours, ask him directly, in one sentence.

Words to borrow

“I'm in my head right now. Give me a minute to find the feeling.”

“I don't need you to be right. I need you to be here.”

“Can you tell me plainly what you meant?”

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE A STRATEGIST

- Say what you mean. Ambiguity costs her days of thinking.
- Enjoy her mind, and argue back. She respects it.
- When she gets precise in a fight, ask how she feels.
- Be patient with her warm-up. It's real once it comes.
- Show your own feelings. It gives her permission.

A RITUAL FOR TWO

The Sunday check-in

Twenty minutes every Sunday: one thing that worked between you this week, one thing that didn't, and one thing each of you needs next week. Feelings first, solutions second.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

I don't have to win to be close.



IN A COUPLE · 04 OF 07

The Trailblazer

Love that leaves room to breathe.

In a couple, you are the freedom. You never try to own him, you're fiercely loyal, and you make things happen. Your growing edge is letting closeness in without bracing.

You both get home from separate weekends, you from a hike, he from his brother's place. You trade stories over takeout, sunburned and happy, truly glad to see each other. That's you in a couple, at full strength: two whole people choosing each other, again and again.

What you bring

FREEDOM

You never try to own him. He gets to be himself, keep his friends and chase his own things.

LOYALTY

When you're in, you're in. You don't play games and you don't waver.

MOMENTUM

You make things happen: the trip, the move, the new plan. Life with you moves forward.

What keeps you well loved

- Respect for your space, time and work.
- A partner with a full life of his own.
- Closeness you choose, not closeness demanded.
- Someone who sees the tiredness under your competence.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The teammate

He's chasing his own goals and celebrates yours. Together you feel like a strong team, not a merger.

The quiet helper

He offers help once, accepts your no, and is simply there when you finally say yes.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The clinger

He needs constant contact and takes your independence personally. The armor goes up fast.

The competitor

Your wins feel like his losses. You start shrinking, or fighting.

IN THE LONG RUN

Years in, two independent people can turn into polite roommates with separate calendars. Freedom is still your gift, but a long love also needs shared ground. Build one ongoing project that belongs to both of you, a garden, a trip you plan for a year, a Sunday ritual, and guard it the way you guard your solo time.

The fights you keep having

"I've got it"

You're moving apartments. He offers to help and you say you've got it. You carry boxes alone all Saturday, exhausted and a bit resentful. He feels shut out of your life.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Asking for help feels like owing something, or being weak.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Let him take one real task, all of it, his way. Thank him without adding "you didn't have to."

The escape hatch

Things get close: a vulnerable talk, a "so what are we?" The next week you're suddenly slammed at work, training for a race, unavailable. He reads it as rejection.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Intimacy can set off an alarm that says you're about to lose yourself.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Name it instead of acting on it: "I'm feeling crowded. It's not you. I need a night, and I'll see you Thursday."

Words to borrow

"I need some space tonight. I'm still in this."

"Actually, yes. I'd love help with that."

"I'm not fine. I'm tired."

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE A TRAILBLAZER

- Don't take her independence personally. It's how she breathes.
- Have passions of your own. She finds that attractive.
- Offer help once, then trust her answer.
- When she needs space, ask when she'll be back, then let her go.
- Notice when she's worn out, and say so gently.

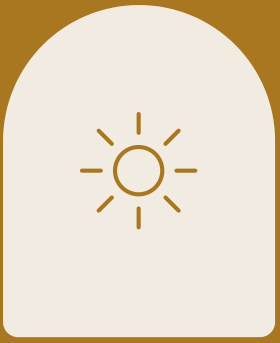
A RITUAL FOR TWO

Together and apart

Once a month, plan something new you do as a team: a trail, a class, a project. And once a month, protect a solo day for each of you, no questions asked.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

Letting him in doesn't mean losing me.



IN A COUPLE · 05 OF 07

The Sovereign

Love that knows its own worth.

In a couple, you are the backbone. You hold the vision, keep things steady, and expect the best of you both. Your growing edge is sharing the weight.

Friends are over, the table is full, and you organized all of it, but tonight he's cooking and you're simply sitting there, glass in hand, laughing. He catches your eye across the room and winks. That's you in a couple, at full strength: powerful, generous, and finally sharing the load.

What you bring

VISION

You see where your life together could go, and you help build it with real plans, not just wishes.

STABILITY

You're steady in a crisis. When things fall apart, you organize, protect and hold the line.

HIGH STANDARDS

You expect the best of both of you, and that lifts the whole relationship.

What keeps you well loved

- A partner who follows through.
- Someone with his own opinions who still listens to yours.
- Big decisions made together.
- A safe place to be soft.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The equal

He has his own authority and enjoys yours. Decisions get made together, and you finally get to rest.

The reliable one

He keeps his word without reminders. You stop scanning for the dropped ball and start trusting.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The passenger

He lets you carry everything. You end up managing him, and resenting it.

The rival

He needs to win every decision, so every disagreement turns into a power struggle.

IN THE LONG RUN

Over time the Sovereign often becomes the CEO of the household, and her partner an employee waiting for instructions. Neither of you chose it; it just happened. Take stock together: who decides what, who carries what. Then hand at least one whole area of life to him, and leave it there.

The fights you keep having

The takeover

He's planning the vacation, slowly. You can't stand it, so you book it yourself. He says, "Then why did you ask me?" You say, "Because you weren't doing it." Both of you feel unappreciated.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

When things are out of your hands, anxiety disguises itself as efficiency.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Agree on a deadline, not a method. If it's his job, it's his until the deadline. Breathe through the in-between.

Never off duty

It's been a brutal month. He asks if you're okay. "I'm fine." He tries to help and you hand him a task. Later you feel completely alone.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Showing need feels like losing your footing.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Say one unarmored sentence: "I'm really tired and I need you to take over tonight." Then let him.

Words to borrow

"You choose. I'll go with it."

"I don't need a solution right now. I need a hug."

"I trust you with this."

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE A SOVEREIGN

- Keep your word. It's how she learns to set things down.
- Have opinions, and share them with respect.
- Take things off her plate fully, without needing supervision.
- Show her it's safe to be soft with you.
- Don't compete with her. Partner with her.

A RITUAL FOR TWO

The hand-off

Each week she hands one decision or task completely to him: no check-ins, no corrections. Each week he asks her one question about how she is really doing, and listens.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

I can set the crown down when I come home.



IN A COUPLE · 06 OF 07

The Nurturer

Love that makes a home.

In a couple, you are the home. You make love feel safe, stay with hard feelings, and show up through everything. Your growing edge is letting care flow back to you.

It's his birthday. The house is warm, the cake is homemade, his friends are laughing. Later, when everyone has gone, he pulls you onto the couch and says, “Your turn. Tell me about your week.” And you do. That's you in a couple, at full strength: loving deeply, and letting it come back.

What you bring

TENDERNESS

You make home a soft place to land. He feels cared for in a way he may never have felt before.

EMOTIONAL DEPTH

You can stay with hard feelings, his and other people's, without rushing to fix them.

DEVOTION

You show up through illness, job loss and grief. Your love is something he can count on.

What keeps you well loved

- To be asked how you are, and listened to.
- A partner who carries his share of the load.
- Care that flows back without hints.
- Permission to rest.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The noticer

He sees your exhaustion and steps in without being asked. Slowly, you learn to receive.

The grown-up

He handles his own life and feelings, so your relationship is a partnership, not a caretaking job.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The project

He needs saving: money, moods, career. You pour in, he takes, and you call it love.

The taker

He enjoys your care, rarely returns it, and makes you feel selfish when you ask.

IN THE LONG RUN

Kids, parents, his career: the Nurturer's load tends to grow every year until there's nothing left of her. A relationship survives the decades only if care flows both ways. Once a year, sit down together and divide the load again, on paper. It isn't unromantic. It's how you stay his partner, not only everyone's caretaker.

The fights you keep having

One pan too many

For months you've done most of the cooking, the kids' schedules, the birthday gifts. One night, over a single unwashed pan, you explode. He's baffled: "It's one pan."

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

You swallowed small needs until they grew into big resentment.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Speak at the first sign of imbalance: "I need you to take over dinner twice a week." Specific, early, calm.

His feelings first

You're upset about something he did. Within minutes you're comforting him about how bad he feels. You go to bed with your own hurt untouched.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Caring for others feels safer than having needs yourself.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Hold your ground gently: "I can see you feel bad. And I still need to tell you how it felt for me."

Words to borrow

"Can you take this off my plate?"

"I need to be looked after tonight."

"No, but thank you for asking."

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE A NURTURER

- Ask how she is, and wait for the real answer.
- Share the mental load, not just the tasks.
- Take care of her without being asked.
- Encourage her to rest. Never make her earn it.
- Handle your own feelings. She's your partner, not your therapist.

A RITUAL FOR TWO

Her night

One evening a week, she's the one being cared for. He plans it, cooks or orders in, handles the kids or the chores, and asks about her life.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

Love that only flows one way is a job, not a partnership.



IN A COUPLE · 07 OF 07

The Dreamer

Love that still believes.

In a couple, you are the lightness. You bring play, curiosity and hope. Your growing edge is saying what you want instead of waiting to be asked.

A Saturday with no plan. You suggest the town two hours away you've never visited, and he says, “Let's go.” You get lost, eat at a strange little diner, and laugh the whole way home. That's you in a couple, at full strength: open, playful, and saying what you want.

What you bring

LIGHTNESS

You keep a relationship from getting heavy. With you, there's always something to laugh about.

CURIOSITY

You want to try things: new places, new ideas, new versions of the two of you.

HOPE

You believe people can change and grow, and that belief often helps them do it.

What keeps you well loved

- A partner who asks what you'd like, and makes room for the answer.
- Clarity about where you stand.
- Encouragement, not critique, when you try something new.
- Someone beside you, not out ahead of you.

BRINGS OUT YOUR BEST

The patient asker

He asks what you'd like and gives you time to find it. Slowly, your own wants come back to the surface.

The clear man

He says how he feels and where this is going. Nothing to guess, so nothing to wait for.

FEEDS YOUR SHADOW

The ambiguous man

Months in, still no label. You wait, you hope, and you put your life on hold.

The director

He decides everything, often well. Slowly you forget you ever had preferences.

IN THE LONG RUN

Years in, Dreamers can quietly fold their own wants into the family plan until they no longer remember what they were. Keep one dream that is yours alone, a class, a trip, a change of career, and say it out loud to him. A partner who loves you will want to make room for it.

The fights you keep having

"I don't mind"

Your anniversary is coming up. "Where should we go?" he asks. "I don't mind." He picks a steakhouse. You wanted the little Italian place, and you're quiet all evening.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

Stating a preference feels risky. Going along feels safe.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Say one want a day, out loud, and stick to it. Start with dinner.

The talk you keep postponing

There's a conversation you're dying to have: living together, children, what comes next. You keep hoping he'll start it. Months go by, the silence becomes anxiety, and finally it erupts as a fight about the dishes.

WHAT'S UNDERNEATH

You're waiting to be chosen instead of choosing.

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Raise it in one imperfect sentence: "I'd like to talk about where we're heading. Can we do that this weekend?"

Words to borrow

"Actually, I'd prefer the Italian place."

"Where do you see us a year from now?"

"I want to try this myself. Will you cheer me on?"

FOR HIM · HOW TO LOVE A DREAMER

- Ask what she'd like, and be patient while she finds her answer.
- Be clear about your feelings and your intentions.
- Celebrate her attempts, especially the messy ones.
- Don't make her decisions for her, even good ones.
- Make room for play. It's how she connects.

A RITUAL FOR TWO

First-time dates

Once a month, do something new to both of you. Every other month she chooses, and she has to name her pick before asking what he thinks.

YOUR LINE TO KEEP

I say what I want, and I let him meet me there.

a last word

Before you decide anything

Knowing your archetype won't tell you whether to stay or go. It tells you what to watch, what to ask for, and where your own part of the dance begins.

People change with the seasons of a relationship. A man who sets off your shadow during a stressful year may be a very different partner once the pressure eases and you have both named the pattern out loud. And you aren't fixed either: the Romantic who chases in March can be the one calmly saying “I need an evening to myself” by June.

So keep your eyes on the basics. Is he kind on ordinary days? Can the two of you disagree and still find your way back to each other? Is he as curious about his own patterns as you are about yours? Then look at your side of it: which archetype takes over when things wobble, and what would her gift look like in that same moment? Practice that, again and again, and choose a partner who makes the practice easier.

Seven questions to ask each other

Over a long dinner, on a road trip, or one question a week. Answer first yourself, then listen without fixing.

1. When do you feel most loved by me?
2. What do you do when you're hurt, and what do you need from me in that moment?
3. What did arguments look like in the home you grew up in?
4. What is one thing you've never quite said to me?
5. How should we split the invisible work of our life?
6. Where would you like us to be in five years?
7. What do I do that makes you feel safe, and what makes you brace?

NOTES